MODULE 1 · KNOW YOUR RIGHTS

RTI (Right to Information)

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Every government office in India, from your municipal corporation to a central ministry, is legally required to answer you if you ask the right question the right way. That's the whole idea behind RTI. It's not a favour anyone is doing you. It's a law, and it works.

1. What Is RTI?

The Right to Information Act, 2005 lets any Indian citizen ask a government office for information it holds, and legally requires that office to respond within a set time. Delayed college result? Pending road repair your area was promised? Where a scholarship fund actually went? You can ask, formally, and get an answer on record.

2. Who Can File, and What You Can Ask

- Any Indian citizen can file an RTI. There's no minimum age in the law itself, though you'll need your own contact details and, for the online route, a payment method.
- You can ask for copies of documents, official data, inspection of records, or certified samples of material held by a public authority.
- You cannot ask for personal opinions, hypothetical questions, or information specifically exempted by law, like matters of national security or ongoing investigations.
- Keep your question specific. "Why hasn't my scholarship been credited" is a request for an opinion. "What is the status of scholarship application number X, and on what date was it processed" is a proper RTI question.

3. How to File an RTI, Step by Step

1. Identify the right public authority, the specific department or office that holds the information you want.

2. For Central Government departments, file online through the official RTI portal (link below). For state government offices, schools, municipal bodies, or police departments, check whether your state has its own RTI portal, since the central portal doesn't cover state matters.

3. Write your request in clear, simple language. State exactly what information you want and for what period, if relevant.

4. Pay the fee, Rs. 10 for most applications, through the portal's payment options (or attach an Indian Postal Order if filing by post).

5. Submit, and save your registration number. You'll need it to track your request or file an appeal later.

6. No online portal for your department? You can file offline too, hand-write or type your application, attach the fee, and submit it in person or by post to the Public Information Officer (PIO) of that office.

Tool Spotlight: RTI Online Portal

rtionline.gov.in is the official Government of India portal for filing RTI applications and first appeals online, for free.

- It currently covers Central Government Ministries, Departments, and a few other central public authorities, not state government offices.
- If your query is about a state department, a government school, a municipal office, or state police, look for that state's own RTI portal, or file offline directly with the office.
- Fee is Rs. 10 for a general application, payable by card, UPI, or net banking. It's free if you hold a BPL (Below Poverty Line) certificate.
- Once submitted, you get a registration number. Use it to track your request or, if 30 days pass with no reply, to file a First Appeal directly from the portal.

RTI Online Portal · *file a Central Government RTI application or first appeal*

4. What Happens After You File

The law puts the government on a clock, and that's the part most people don't realise they can hold offices to.

- The public authority must respond within 30 days of receiving your application.
- If the matter involves someone's life or liberty, like a wrongful detention, the response window shrinks to 48 hours.
- If they miss the deadline entirely, the law says the information must be given to you free of cost.
- If your request gets transferred to a different department because you filed with the wrong office, that adds a little time, but it isn't a rejection, it's a redirect.= ADD SPECOFC STATS

5. If They Don't Answer, or Deny You

This is where most people stop, and where you don't have to.

1. File a First Appeal, addressed to the First Appellate Authority of the same department, within 30 days of the deadline passing or the denial. There's no extra fee for this.

2. The Appellate Authority is expected to decide within 30 days, extendable by 15 more days with a written reason.

3. Still no resolution? File a Second Appeal with the Central Information Commission (CIC), or your State Information Commission for state matters, within 90 days.

Central Information Commission (CIC) · *file a second appeal or complaint against a Central Government department*

A Few Myths, Busted

Myth	Fact
RTI is only for journalists, lawyers, or activists.	Any Indian citizen can file one. Students use it to check exam or scholarship records all the time.
You need a lawyer or an agent to file an RTI.	You can write and submit it yourself in a few minutes. No legal help is required.
The government can just ignore your RTI if it's inconvenient.	Ignoring the deadline has a real consequence: the information becomes free, and you can escalate through appeal.

Useful Links

RTI Online Portal · *file a Central Government RTI application or first appeal*

Central Information Commission (CIC) · *second appeals and complaints for Central Government matters*

RTI Portal Gateway · *find Public Information Officers and state RTI portal links*

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